

PREPOSITIONS

A Complete Study Guide for IN, ON, AT, BY, and More

IN · ON · AT
BY · FOR · WITH

Rules, usage, common confusions, and 35 practice questions graded Easy → Medium → Hard, with a full answer key and explanations.

Prepared for focused C-CAT practice

1. What Are Prepositions?

A preposition is a word placed before a noun, pronoun, or noun phrase to show its relationship with another word in the sentence — usually relating to **place, time, direction, manner, agency, or reason**. Prepositions are small, frequently repeated words (in, on, at, by, for, with, from, to, of, about, etc.), but they cause a disproportionate number of mistakes because their correct use often depends on **fixed convention** rather than logic.

Core idea to remember: A preposition always needs an "object" after it (a noun, pronoun, or -ing form). It never stands alone, and it never directly precedes a plain verb (e.g., NOT "good at swim," but "good at swimming").

Why This Topic Matters for C-CAT

Preposition questions test three main things: (1) whether you know the standard place/time rules for IN, ON, AT; (2) whether you know fixed preposition pairings with specific verbs, adjectives, and nouns (e.g., "depend ON," "good AT," "interested IN"); and (3) whether you can spot a wrong, missing, or extra preposition in a sentence. Because many of these are fixed expressions with no underlying logic, the fastest way to score well is repeated exposure plus a solid reference table — which is exactly what this guide gives you.

2. IN, ON, AT — Prepositions of Place

These three are the most commonly tested prepositions. They follow a "zoom level" logic: AT is the most precise (a point), ON is for surfaces/lines, and IN is for enclosed spaces/areas.

Preposition	Used For	Examples
AT	A specific point or exact location	<i>at the door, at the bus stop, at the corner, at home, at the airport, at 221B Baker Street</i>
ON	A surface, line, or something resting on top of something	<i>on the table, on the wall, on the page, on the bridge, on the first floor (British usage), on the border</i>
IN	An enclosed space, area, or large region	<i>in the box, in the room, in the city, in India, in the garden, in the water</i>

Quick visual: Think of AT as a dot (•), ON as a flat surface (—), and IN as a container ([]). "At the station" (a point on the map), "on the platform" (a surface you stand on), "in the station building" (an enclosed space).

2.1 Common Place Confusions

Phrase	Correct Preposition	Why
___ the corner (of a street)	at the corner	specific point
___ the corner (of a room)	in the corner	enclosed space within a room
___ the photo / ___ the picture	in the photo	treated as a bounded space
___ a car	in a car	enclosed vehicle
___ a bus / train / plane / ship	on a bus/train/plane/ship	treated as a surface/public transport convention
___ a bicycle / motorcycle	on a bicycle	you sit "on" two-wheelers, not "in"
___ the world	in the world	large enclosed/global area
___ the internet / ___ Instagram	on the internet, on Instagram	platforms/surfaces by convention

3. IN, ON, AT — Prepositions of Time

Preposition	Used For	Examples
AT	Precise clock times, festivals (as a point in time), specific moments	<i>at 6 p.m., at noon, at midnight, at Diwali, at the moment, at the same time</i>
ON	Days, dates, specific named occasions	<i>on Monday, on 15 August, on my birthday, on Independence Day, on the weekend (American usage)</i>

IN	Months, years, seasons, centuries, parts of the day (longer/broader time periods)	<i>in March, in 2025, in summer, in the 21st century, in the morning/afternoon/evening</i>
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Exception to remember: We say **at night** (not "in the night" in standard usage), but **in the morning/afternoon/evening**. This single exception is tested often.

3.1 Time "Zoom Level" Memory Trick

Just like with place, time follows the same zoom logic:

- **AT** = the smallest/most exact point in time (a clock time)
- **ON** = a single day/date (a line on the calendar)
- **IN** = a longer enclosed stretch (a month, year, season, century)

4. Prepositions of Movement and Direction

Preposition	Meaning/Use	Example
to	movement toward a destination	<i>She walked to the market.</i>
into	movement from outside to inside	<i>He jumped into the pool.</i>
onto	movement to a surface/position	<i>The cat climbed onto the roof.</i>
out of	movement from inside to outside	<i>She walked out of the office.</i>
through	movement from one side to the other, passing inside something	<i>We drove through the tunnel.</i>
across	movement from one side of a surface/area to the other	<i>They swam across the river.</i>
along	movement following the length of something	<i>We walked along the beach.</i>
past	movement beyond a point	<i>He drove past the school.</i>
towards	movement in the direction of, not necessarily reaching	<i>The ship sailed towards the horizon.</i>
up / down	movement to a higher/lower position	<i>She climbed up the stairs; he ran down the hill.</i>

To vs At with verbs of motion: "Throw the ball to him" (movement, destination) vs. "Throw the ball at him" (aiming with intent/force). Similarly, "shout to someone" (to communicate across distance) vs. "shout at someone" (in anger).

5. Fixed Preposition Pairings (Verb / Adjective / Noun + Preposition)

This is the single highest-yield section for exams. These combinations don't follow a logical rule — they must simply be memorised as fixed expressions.

5.1 Verb + Preposition

Verb + Preposition	Example
depend ON	<i>Success depends on hard work.</i>
rely ON	<i>You can rely on him.</i>
insist ON	<i>She insisted on paying the bill.</i>
apologise/apologize FOR	<i>He apologised for being late.</i>
congratulate someone ON	<i>They congratulated her on the win.</i>
complain ABOUT	<i>Customers complained about the service.</i>
succeed IN	<i>She succeeded in passing the exam.</i>
believe IN	<i>He believes in hard work.</i>

differ FROM	<i>This model differs from the older one.</i>
deal WITH	<i>We need to deal with this issue.</i>
consist OF	<i>The team consists of five members.</i>
arrive AT (a place/building) / arrive IN (a city/country)	<i>We arrived at the station; they arrived in Mumbai.</i>
compare TO (different things) / compare WITH (similar things)	<i>Life is compared to a journey; compare this draft with the last one.</i>
object TO	<i>I object to this plan.</i>
look FORWARD TO	<i>We look forward to meeting you.</i>
provide someone WITH something	<i>The school provided students with books.</i>
remind someone OF	<i>This song reminds me of college.</i>
react TO	<i>He reacted angrily to the news.</i>
recover FROM	<i>She recovered from her illness.</i>
aim AT	<i>The advertisement is aimed at teenagers.</i>

5.2 Adjective + Preposition

Adjective + Preposition	Example
good/bad AT	<i>She is good at maths.</i>
interested IN	<i>He is interested in history.</i>
afraid/scared OF	<i>Children are often afraid of the dark.</i>
proud OF	<i>We are proud of you.</i>
angry/upset WITH (a person), angry ABOUT (a situation)	<i>She was angry with him about the delay.</i>
satisfied/pleased WITH	<i>I am satisfied with the results.</i>
responsible FOR	<i>He is responsible for the project.</i>
similar TO	<i>This design is similar to the old one.</i>
different FROM	<i>My opinion is different from yours.</i>
aware OF	<i>Are you aware of the risks?</i>
famous FOR	<i>Paris is famous for the Eiffel Tower.</i>
married TO	<i>She is married to a doctor.</i>
capable OF	<i>He is capable of doing better.</i>
tired OF	<i>I am tired of waiting.</i>
sure/certain OF (or ABOUT)	<i>Are you sure of/about this decision?</i>

5.3 Noun + Preposition

Noun + Preposition	Example
reason FOR	<i>What is the reason for the delay?</i>
solution TO	<i>We found a solution to the problem.</i>
increase/decrease IN	<i>There was an increase in sales.</i>
access TO	<i>Students need access to the library.</i>
relationship/connection BETWEEN (two things), WITH (a person)	<i>There's a connection between diet and health; she has a good relationship with her boss.</i>
demand FOR	<i>There is a high demand for skilled workers.</i>
need FOR	<i>There is a need for better roads.</i>
respect FOR	<i>She has great respect for her teachers.</i>
advantage/disadvantage OF	<i>What are the advantages of this method?</i>

Common error: "married with" and "married to" are both used, but they mean different things — "married to [a person]" (correct standard form) vs. "married with children" (meaning "and having children," not describing the spouse). Don't confuse the two.

6. BY, WITH, FROM, OF — Agency, Means, and Origin

Preposition	Used For	Examples
BY	The agent/doer in passive voice; method of transport; deadline time	<i>The novel was written by her; we travelled by train; submit it by Friday</i>
WITH	The instrument/tool used; accompaniment; possession of a feature	<i>She cut the rope with scissors; he came with his brother; a man with a beard</i>
FROM	Origin, source, starting point, distinguishing	<i>She is from Pune; the smell came from the kitchen; he can't tell right from wrong</i>
OF	Belonging, composition, quantity, description	<i>the capital of France; a cup of tea; a man of integrity; made of wood</i>

BY vs WITH for tools: A common confusion. We normally use WITH for a physical tool held in the hand ("cut with a knife," "write with a pen"), and BY for a method, means, or mode ("by hand," "by post," "by mistake," "travel by car"). "By bus" and "with a bus" are not interchangeable — only "by bus" is correct.

7. When NOT to Use a Preposition

This is where many students lose marks — adding an unnecessary preposition, or using a preposition where the verb already includes the meaning (especially with verbs from Indian-English habits that differ from standard usage).

Incorrect (extra preposition)	Correct
Please discuss about this matter.	Please discuss this matter.
She requested for a leave.	She requested a leave.
He demanded for justice.	He demanded justice.
I reached at the station.	I reached the station. (or "arrived at the station")
She emphasized on the need for change.	She emphasized the need for change.
Let us discuss about the plan.	Let us discuss the plan.
He ordered for a pizza.	He ordered a pizza.
Please return back the book.	Please return the book.

Why this happens: Verbs like discuss, request, demand, emphasize, reach (a destination), order, and return are already "transitive" — they take a direct object without needing a preposition. Adding "about," "for," or "at" after them is a classic Indian-English error frequently tested in competitive exams.

7.1 Other Zero-Preposition Situations

Situation	Example
Before "home" (as a destination, with verbs of motion)	<i>She went home. (NOT "went to home")</i>
Before "next," "last," "this," "every" + day/week/month/year	<i>I will call you next week. (NOT "in next week")</i>
Before "yesterday," "today," "tomorrow"	<i>We met yesterday. (NOT "on yesterday")</i>

8. Quick-Revision Cheat Sheet

Rule	One-Line Reminder
Place	AT = point, ON = surface, IN = enclosed space.

Time	AT = clock time, ON = day/date, IN = month/year/season/century. Exception: "at night" but "in the morning/afternoon/evening."
Movement	to (toward), into (entering), onto (surface), out of (exiting), through (passing inside), across (side to side), along (length-wise).
Fixed pairings	Memorise verb/adjective/noun + preposition combos — they are not logical, they are conventional (good at, interested in, depend on, afraid of).
Agency/means	BY = doer/method/deadline, WITH = tool/accompaniment, FROM = origin/source, OF = belonging/composition.
No preposition needed	discuss, request, demand, emphasize, reach, order, return (already transitive) + home/yesterday/today/tomorrow/next-last-this-every + time word.

Exam strategy: If a sentence has a verb known to be "extra-preposition-prone" (discuss, request, demand, emphasize, reach, order), check first whether the preposition after it is unnecessary. If the blank is after IN/ON/AT, ask: is this a point (AT), a surface/day (ON), or an enclosed space/longer time period (IN)? For everything else, rely on the fixed-pairing tables above.

9. Practice Questions (35) — Easy → Medium → Hard

Choose the most appropriate preposition to fill the blank (or identify the correct usage). Answers and explanations are provided in Section 10. Try to attempt all questions before checking the key.

Level 1: Easy (Q1-Q12)

Q1. Easy The keys are ___ the table.

- A) in
- B) on
- C) at
- D) by

Q2. Easy We will meet ___ 6 p.m. at the cafe.

- A) in
- B) on
- C) at
- D) for

Q3. Easy She was born ___ 2001.

- A) in
- B) on
- C) at
- D) since

Q4. Easy He is good ___ playing chess.

- A) in
- B) on
- C) at
- D) with

Q5. Easy The students are sitting ___ the classroom.

- A) in
- B) on
- C) at
- D) to

Q6. Easy She is afraid ___ spiders.

- A) from
- B) of
- C) with
- D) at

Q7. Easy We travelled to Goa ___ train.

- A) with
- B) in
- C) by
- D) on

Q8. Easy The meeting is scheduled ___ Monday.

- A) in
- B) on
- C) at
- D) by

Q9. Easy He cut the cake ___ a knife.

- A) by
 - B) with
 - C) from
 - D) at
-

Q10. Easy I am interested ___ learning Spanish.

- A) at
 - B) for
 - C) in
 - D) on
-

Q11. Easy The cat jumped ___ the wall.

- A) onto
 - B) in
 - C) at
 - D) for
-

Q12. Easy She lives ___ Pune.

- A) at
 - B) on
 - C) in
 - D) to
-

Level 2: Medium (Q13-Q24)

Q13. Medium Success depends ___ consistent effort.

- A) of
 - B) on
 - C) for
 - D) at
-

Q14. Medium Choose the correct sentence:

- A) Please discuss about the proposal in the meeting.
 - B) Please discuss the proposal in the meeting.
 - C) Please discuss for the proposal in the meeting.
 - D) Please discuss on the proposal in the meeting.
-

Q15. Medium We usually go for a walk ___ the evening.

- A) at
 - B) on
 - C) in
 - D) by
-

Q16. Medium The train arrived ___ Chennai an hour late.

- A) at
 - B) in
 - C) on
 - D) to
-

Q17. Medium She is married ___ a software engineer.

- A) with
 - B) for
 - C) to
 - D) at
-

Q18. Medium Identify the correct sentence:

- A) She reached at the airport on time.
 - B) She reached to the airport on time.
 - C) She reached the airport on time.
 - D) She reached in the airport on time.
-

Q19. Medium He apologised ___ arriving late to the interview.

- A) of
 - B) for
 - C) about
 - D) at
-

Q20. Medium The company reported a sharp increase ___ profits this quarter.

- A) of
 - B) at
 - C) in
 - D) on
-

Q21. Medium Choose the option that correctly completes: "He is responsible ___ managing the team's budget."

- A) of
 - B) for
 - C) with
 - D) at
-

Q22. Medium Please submit your assignment ___ Friday at the latest.

- A) until
 - B) by
 - C) since
 - D) at
-

Q23. Medium Identify the sentence with the preposition error:

- A) She is proud of her achievements.
 - B) He is capable of leading the team.
 - C) They congratulated her for the promotion.
 - D) We are aware of the risks involved.
-

Q24. Medium This phone model is quite different ___ the previous one.

- A) than
 - B) of
 - C) from
 - D) with
-

Level 3: Hard (Q25-Q35)

Q25. Hard Choose the sentence with correct preposition usage:

- A) He requested for a transfer to the Pune branch.
 - B) He requested a transfer to the Pune branch.
 - C) He requested about a transfer to the Pune branch.
 - D) He requested of a transfer to the Pune branch.
-

Q26. Hard Which sentence uses BY and WITH correctly together?

- A) The letter was written with him and signed by a pen.
 - B) The letter was written by him and signed with a pen.
 - C) The letter was written by a pen and signed with him.
 - D) The letter was written with a pen by signed him.
-

Q27. Hard Identify the grammatically correct sentence:

- A) The advantages of this plan outweigh the disadvantages of it.
 - B) The advantages for this plan outweigh the disadvantages with it.
 - C) The advantages on this plan outweigh the disadvantages at it.
 - D) The advantages in this plan outweigh the disadvantages of it.
-

Q28. Hard Spot the sentence that is already fully correct:

- A) We discussed about the issue and arrived to a decision by evening.
 - B) We discussed the issue and arrived at a decision by evening.
 - C) We discussed on the issue and arrived in a decision by evening.
 - D) We discussed for the issue and arrived on a decision by evening.
-

Q29. Hard Choose the correct option: "The advertisement is aimed ___ young professionals who are interested ___ fitness."

- A) at / in
 - B) to / on
 - C) for / at
 - D) on / for
-

Q30. Hard Which sentence correctly distinguishes "compare to" from "compare with"?

- A) Life is often compared with a journey; please compare this draft to the earlier version.
 - B) Life is often compared to a journey; please compare this draft with the earlier version.
 - C) Life is often compared at a journey; please compare this draft for the earlier version.
 - D) Life is often compared of a journey; please compare this draft on the earlier version.
-

Q31. Hard Identify the only INCORRECT sentence:

- A) She emphasized the importance of punctuality.
 - B) He ordered a coffee and a sandwich.
 - C) They demanded for an explanation from the manager.
 - D) The teacher insisted on submitting the homework on time.
-

Q32. Hard Choose the option that correctly fills both blanks: "There is a high demand ___ skilled workers, but the supply differs greatly ___ region to region."

- A) of / with
 - B) for / from
 - C) for / for
 - D) on / between
-

Q33. Hard Which sentence correctly uses a zero-preposition rule?

- A) She went to home early because she felt unwell.
 - B) She went home early because she felt unwell.
 - C) She went at home early because she felt unwell.
 - D) She went on home early because she felt unwell.
-

Q34. Hard Spot the correctly formed sentence regarding time prepositions:

- A) The shop is closed at night but opens in the morning.
 - B) The shop is closed in night but opens at the morning.
 - C) The shop is closed on night but opens on the morning.
 - D) The shop is closed in the night but opens on morning.
-

Q35. Hard Identify the only CORRECT sentence:

- A) The manager emphasized on the need for better communication.
 - B) The manager emphasized about the need for better communication.
 - C) The manager emphasized the need for better communication.
 - D) The manager emphasized for the need for better communication.
-

10. Answer Key with Explanations

Q#	Answer	Why
1	B) on	Keys rest on the surface of the table → ON.
2	C) at	A precise clock time always takes AT.
3	A) in	A year takes IN.
4	C) at	Fixed adjective pairing: "good at" + activity.
5	A) in	The classroom is an enclosed space → IN.
6	B) of	Fixed adjective pairing: "afraid of."
7	C) by	Mode of transport uses BY — "by train."
8	B) on	A specific day takes ON — "on Monday."
9	B) with	A physical tool held in the hand takes WITH — "with a knife."
10	C) in	Fixed adjective pairing: "interested in."
11	A) onto	Movement ending on a surface takes ONTO.
12	C) in	Cities/countries (enclosed regions) take IN.
13	B) on	Fixed verb pairing: "depend on."
14	B	"Discuss" is already transitive and needs no preposition; "discuss about" is a common error.
15	C) in	Parts of the day (morning/afternoon/evening) take IN — exception being "at night."
16	B) in	"Arrive in" is used for cities/countries; "arrive at" is used for specific buildings/points.
17	C) to	Fixed pairing: "married to" (a person).
18	C	"Reach" is already transitive — no preposition is needed before the destination.
19	B) for	Fixed verb pairing: "apologise for" + the reason/action.
20	C) in	Fixed noun pairing: "increase in" + the thing that increased.
21	B) for	Fixed adjective pairing: "responsible for."
22	B) by	BY is used for a deadline — "submit by Friday" means no later than Friday.
23	C	The correct fixed pairing is "congratulate someone ON," not "congratulate... for." Option C should read "congratulated her on the promotion."
24	C) from	Fixed adjective pairing: "different from" (standard form, though "different than" is common informally in American English).
25	B	"Request" is already transitive; "requested for" is a common but incorrect extra-preposition error.
26	B	BY shows the agent/doer ("written by him"), and WITH shows the tool used ("signed with a pen").
27	A	"Advantages of" and "disadvantages of" are the correct fixed noun pairings; "of it" correctly refers back to the plan.
28	B	"Discuss" needs no preposition, and "arrive at a decision" (reaching a conclusion) is the correct fixed expression, not "arrive to/in a decision."
29	A	Fixed pairings: "aimed at" (a target audience) and "interested in" (a topic).
30	B	"Compare to" is used when highlighting similarity between different types of things (life vs. a journey); "compare with" is used when examining two similar things side by side (two drafts).
31	C	"Demand" is already transitive; "demanded for an explanation" should be "demanded an explanation." This is the incorrect sentence.
32	B	Fixed pairings: "demand for" (a noun pairing) and "differs from" (region to region uses "from...to" structure, but the key fixed verb form is "differ from").
33	B	"Home" takes no preposition after verbs of motion like "go," "come," "return" — "went home," not "went to home."
34	A	"At night" is the standard fixed exception, while "in the morning" follows the regular IN rule for parts of the day.
35	C	"Emphasize" is already transitive and takes a direct object with no preposition; "emphasized on/about/for" are all common but incorrect extra-preposition errors.

How to use this key: For every question you got wrong, go back to the relevant rule in Sections 2–7, re-read the rule, and

try to explain the answer in your own words before moving to the next question. Pay special attention to Section 5 (fixed pairings) and Section 7 (zero preposition) — these two sections account for the majority of real exam mistakes.